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From the editor-in-chief

I am in a way a child of the Partition. I was born in Lahore but on Partition my family moved to India. Although I was too young to remember anything about Partition, I've been brought up with stories about it. It is true to say that anyone who remembers being witness to the Partition of India carries it inside them forever. It would seem that Independent India itself, 62 years old this month, has not been able to shake off the memory or erase the scars of that event, which was both epoch-making and calamitous, political yet personal.

Recently expelled BJP leader Jaswant Singh's latest book *Jinnah: India-Partition-Independence* has stirred up interest and argument over Partition yet again. This is largely because he chose to refashion the portrait of the man India believes was responsible for Partition, Mohammad Ali Jinnah, the founding father of Pakistan.

In the mythology of popular Indian history, Jinnah is a much-reviled and demonised figure. He is seen as the stubborn leader who stoked sectarian divisions that led to the creation of Pakistan. Singh's alternative version of Jinnah is neither new nor radical. Singh says Jinnah was a secular leader who was pushed to the wall and demanded a separate state only due to the politics between the Congress and Muslim League. His suggestion that Indian historical heroes like Jawaharlal Nehru and Vallabhbhai Patel had as much a part to play in Partition as Jinnah has caused a furore.

No matter where you stand in the debate, Jinnah has certainly stirred a hornets' nest in the BJP yet again. We have featured Pakistan's Quaid-i-Azam on our cover twice, as recently as June 2005, when L.K. Advani made his famous visit across the border where he too, like Singh, declared Jinnah to be a secularist. It is ironic that the BJP, the party of Hindutva, should proclaim Jinnah as the great nationalist. The joke is that Jinnah is not only the Father of Pakistan but of Hindutva too, as without Pakistan, there would be no Hindutva.

Leaving historical debate only to politicians, however, can be dangerous as their motives often extend beyond pure scholarship. Since our politicians are not known for their historical perspective, we decided to tackle the thorny subject of Partition by asking historians and specialists to give us their understanding of a watershed event in the life of our nation.

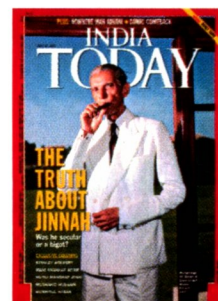
Our cover story this week, an in-depth exploration of Partition, is put together by Editor-at-Large S. Prasannarajan. It features special essays by South Asian expert Sunil Khilnani, Pakistani historian Ayesha Jalal and journalist Mark Tully among others.

Their differing perspectives offer us the singular truth that no one individual was responsible for the division of one country into two. It was a combination of national circumstances and individual frailties.

Understanding an event like Partition through black and white simplifications is not the way to know our history. Any debate that expands our knowledge of the complexities involved in history must be encouraged. And so it must be with the tangled web that is Partition.

A confident country after all, is one that is neither trapped by its past nor haunted by it. It is a country that has come to terms with its history. It's time we did.

(Aroon Purie)



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